

THE MANDATE OF THE CHURCH

INTRO:

I am a champion of the Church. Some have a pessimistic view of the Church, but I am not one of them. Some believe the church is going to cease to exist, I couldn't disagree more. (One person told me, "*The Church is going away!*" I said, "*How right you are!* LOL)

I have been in Church my entire life. There has never been a season of my life that doesn't involve the Church. It is a complete accident that I wasn't born in a Church.

- I was dedicated to the Lord in a church...
- I attended Sunday School in a church...
- I was born again in a church...
- I was baptized in water through a church...
- I was baptized in Holy Spirit in a church... (You can call me, The Don!

LOL)

- I was called to ministry in a church...
- I was married in a church...
- I raised my family in a church
- I dedicated my children to the Lord in a church...
- I have pastored a church for forty-seven years...
- My funeral will be held in a church...
- I am a product of the Church therefore I am a champion of the Church...

Trust me, the church is not going to cease to exist! ***“Upon this rock...”*** He is coming back for ***“A glorious church that does not have spot, wrinkle, or any such thing!”***

If the Church is going to endure, what is the mandate of the Church? To answer this question, I want to use the dedication of Solomons Temple.

The setting of the sixth chapter of 2

Chronicles is as follows:

- Solomon had built a house for God...
- The construction of the Temple had been completed...
- The Temple had been furnished according to the instructions of the Lord...
- The people had gathered for the dedication of this historic structure...
- Solomon spoke to the people outlining how the building had come about...
(“You have spoken with your mouth and performed it with your hand.”) If you are engaged in building His Church, look closely! His hand is on top of your hands!
- Solomon reminded God of His promises to His people and staked a claim for those promises... I am here to stake a claim tonight for the fulfillment of the mandate of the 21st Century Church.

It is my belief that the prayer of Solomon

reflects the mandate of the Church.

THE MANDATE OF THE CHURCH IS THAT IT WILL BE A PLACE OF FORGIVENESS

2 Chronicles 6:21 (NKJV) *“May You hear the supplications of Your servant and of Your people Israel, when they pray toward this place. Hear from heaven Your dwelling place, and when You hear, forgive.”*

Solomon’s request was that God, and the people, would be quick to forgive sinners and one another. He prayed that the Temple would always be a place of forgiveness.

Certainly, God is a God of forgiveness. Therefore, the Church should be a place of forgiveness. When people come to Christ, we must forgive them and assist them in forgiving themselves. Psalm 103:12 (NKJV)

“As far as the east is from the west, So far has He removed our transgressions from us.”

In order to fulfill the mandate of the Lord, the Church must become known for it's willingness to forgive!

THE MANDATE OF THE CHURCH IS TO BE A PLACE OF MERCY

2 Chronicles 6:22-23 (NKJV) ***“If anyone sins against his neighbor, and is forced to take an oath, and comes and takes an oath before Your altar in this temple, 23 then hear from heaven, and act, and judge Your servants, bringing retribution on the wicked by bringing his way on his own head, and justifying the righteous by giving him according to his righteousness.”***

Solomon was praying that the Temple would be a place of mercy! His prayer was that...

- If someone has taken an oath, they cannot live up to... Let this be a house of mercy!
- If anyone sins against his neighbor... Let this be a house of mercy!
- If anyone misses the mark... Let this be a house of mercy!
- In retribution... Let this be a house of mercy!

When are we going to stop killing our wounded? When are we going to stop beating the brakes off of those who show mercy? The military will risk the lives of unwounded soldiers to retrieve a dead body from the battlefield!

We are okay with having God's mercy meter reset in our lives every day, but I am wondering how willing we are to push the reset button for others.

If we are going to fulfill our mandate, the

Church must be a place marked by mercy!

THE MANDATE OF THE CHURCH IS TO BE A PLACE OF RESTORATION

2 Chronicles 6:24-25 (NKJV) *“If Your people Israel are defeated before an enemy because they have sinned against You, and return and confess Your name, and pray and make supplication before You in this temple, 25 then hear from heaven and forgive the sin of Your people Israel, and bring them back to the land which You gave to them and their fathers.”*

Solomon was asking God to cause the Temple to always be a place of restoration. He wanted the Temple default to be restoration.

It is one thing to have mercy and forgive; it is another matter to dirty our hands in the process of restoration! Restoration is both an

attitude and an activity.

Solomon said:

- When they sin... Restore them!
- When they are defeated... Restore them!
- When they are taken captive... Restore them!
- When they cry out to you... Restore them!

The constant state of God's activity is rescue!

There are those out there who have sinned against God, you, and your church. If we are going to reach them, we must start here and now to be people of restoration who build a house of restoration!

Don't forget... ***“All have sinned and come short of the glory of God.”***

(We fix wrecks – Car going down the road

sideways – Went to the wrong body shop!)

THE MANDATE OF THE CHURCH IS TO BE A PLACE OF HARVEST AND PROSPERITY

2 Chronicles 6:26-27 (NKJV) *“When the heavens are shut up and there is no rain because they have sinned against You, when they pray toward this place and confess Your name, and turn from their sin because You afflict them, 27 then hear in heaven, and forgive the sin of Your servants, Your people Israel, that You may teach them the good way in which they should walk; and send rain on Your land which You have given to Your people as an inheritance.”*

Solomon recognized that the result of the sins of the people manifests itself by dragging them down into an impoverished condition. Despite this, he asked God,

“When the people pray in or toward the Temple that the house of the Lord would produce harvest and eventually prosperity!”

Listen to his prayer...

- When they sin against you... Turn them toward the house of harvest and prosperity!
- When the Heavens are shut up... Turn them toward the house of harvest and prosperity!
- When they are impoverished... Turn them toward the house of harvest and prosperity!
- When they have no food... Turn them toward the house of harvest and prosperity!

Do you know anyone who is broke, busted, and disgusted? The preaching, teaching and discipleship of the Church should lead them out of poverty and into prosperity!

I was raised in poverty! Do you know where I learned how to get out of a lifestyle of poverty? The church! I knew I couldn't work my way out – I had to give my way out!

Is there a parent in here that wants any of their children to struggle one day in the pit of poverty? We serve a ***“How much more God!”***

The Mandate of the Church is to be a place of harvest and prosperity!

(Tell Matt and Janaay Tatum story)
(Receive Missions Offering)